

Indian Army troops under UN command near Élisabethville airport, Katanga, 15 November 1961. The Indian Army has participated in 49 of the 71 UN peacekeeping missions, providing over 253,000 personnel for service around the world. In the UN's first 'peace enforcement operation', Brigadier K.A.S. Raja's 99 Infantry Brigade Group commenced operations in Congo's Katanga province on 31 December 1961 and regained full control despite stiff resistance offered by a breakaway faction (the Katangese Gendarmerie) led by Belgian officers. Major General (later Lieutenant General) Dewan Prem Chand commanded HQ Katanga Area (UN) during the operations. (Smith Archive/Alamy Stock Photo)

The armoured corps was slow off the blocks with the first additional regiments not raised until several years after partition, though India acquired 200 Sherman medium tanks from US surplus stocks in 1951, followed by 220 Centurion main battle tanks from Britain in 1955. Three new armoured regiments (20, 62 and 63) were raised in 1956–57, but the